At the Place of Ashamnu: The Lulav, the Blessing of Dan, Naphtali and Asher, and the Shechinah Among Those Who Learn

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The Daily Learning Portions

- **Chumash:** Vezot Haberachah, 5th aliyah — Devarim 33:22–26 (Dan, Naphtali, Asher; bars of iron and copper; *Ein ka-El Yeshurun*)
- **Festival kriah (Israel):** Bamidbar 29:29–34 — musaf of the sixth day (eight bulls)
- **Tehillim:** Chapters 97–103
- **Tanya:** Iggeret HaKodesh, beginning of Epistle 23
- **Rambam (3 chapters):** Hilchot Mikvaot 8–10
- **Rambam (1 chapter):** Continuation in the mikveh cycle
- **Sefer HaMitzvot:** Positive Commandment 109 — immersion in a mikveh
- **Hayom Yom:** Tishrei 20 — during the *naanuim*, touch the chest with the lulav at the spot one strikes for *Ashamnu*
- **Customs:** Eat in the sukkah; Four Species; no tefillin (Chabad on Chol HaMoed); Simchat Beit HaShoeivah; *L'Dovid Hashem Ori* through Hoshana Rabbah; Hoshana Rabbah begins on the night of Thursday, 1 October 2026

The same five verses of Vezot Haberachah were learned on 13 Tishrei, between Yom Kippur and the first night of the festival. They return now from inside the hut, with the species in the hand and the ushpiza of Yosef at the table. The text has not changed. The vessel has.

I. The Frame: Bitterness That Learns How to Wave

Hayom Yom for the twentieth of Tishrei is a physical instruction with a theology inside it.

During the movements of the lulav, one should touch the chest with the lulav at the spot one strikes his heart for *Ashamnu*. The Frierdiker Rebbe said at a farbrengen that this practice is similar to the idea that only through the earnestness before davening — when one is embittered over his sins — can there afterwards be an emotional excitement in davening.

The species do not skip the heart. They land first on the place of confession. Then they go out: east, south, west, north, up, down. Joy that has not touched *Ashamnu* is a decoration. Joy that has touched it is the festival the Torah commanded.

The portions agree. Moses blesses the border lion, the satisfied lake-tribe, and the oil-tribe, then lifts the whole people: there is none like G-d, O Jeshurun, riding the heavens to your help. The Alter Rebbe opens Iggeret 23 by placing the Shechinah *among* ten who learn together — not merely hovering over them. Rambam measures how waters join, which grades of mikveh purify

whom, and how doubt is resolved toward *taharah*. Tehillim 97–103 open with *Hashem malach* and plant light for the righteous. Yosef sits as ushpiza: the man who remained Yosef in a house that was not his, and then fed the world from a storehouse that was.

Two mornings to Hoshana Rabbah. The willows will be beaten. The seals of the season will be asked to close in mercy. Today the work is simpler and harder: let the lulav find the heart before it finds the six directions.

II. Chumash: Dan, Naphtali, Asher — Then the Bars, Then Jeshurun

Dan — a whelp that springs (Devarim 33:22)

> *And of Dan he said: Dan is a lion's whelp that leaps forth from Bashan.*

Rashi, from the Sifrei, sets Dan among the lion-tribes because he sits on the border. *Yezanek min haBashan* is read two ways. Onkelos: his land drinks the waters that stream from Bashan; the Jordan issues from the cave of Paneas in Dan's northern holding. The second reading: one source that later divides. Dan first took a northwest holding; when it did not suffice he rose and took Leshem in the northeast (Yehoshua 19:47). One source, two inheritances.

On 13 Tishrei the verse was *lechatchilah ariber* — the Maharash's maxim in tribal form. Inside the sukkah it is something adjacent. A lion's whelp is still a lion, but a whelp. Strength is present before it is mature. The hut is also a whelp of a house: thin walls, unfinished roof, seven days only. It is not less a dwelling for that. Chinuch can say the line without a sermon. You do not wait until the walls are stone to sit under Heaven.

Naphtali — satisfied, and commanded to possess (33:23)

> *And of Naphtali he said: Naphtali, sated with favor and full of the blessing of the Lord — possess the sea and the south.*

Rashi: the land itself would satisfy its inhabitants; the Kinneret fell in his portion, with a rope's length of southern shore for the nets. *Yerashah* is an imperative. The Masorah lists it with the accented command-forms. Satisfaction does not cancel the command to take.

Chol HaMoed is the week that tests this exact pairing. The festival has already begun. The joy is already present. The command has not expired. Possess the sea and the south — keep taking the species, keep eating in the hut, keep drawing water with joy — *because* you are already sated, not because you are still empty. A republic of the covenant works the same way. Consent is not a mood that arrives once. It is a possession that must be exercised while favor is already in the house.

Asher — iron, copper, and oil (33:24–25)

> *And of Asher he said: Blessed among sons is Asher; let him be favored by his brothers, and dip his foot in oil. Iron and copper shall be your bars, and as your days, so shall your strength be.*

Rashi reads the oil as the richness of Asher's land — so plentiful one could dip a foot. The bars are the locks of the Land: the border tribes close the country as a man closes a courtyard. *Ucheyamecha dobe'echa* is read as strength matching the days, or as the days themselves being a flowing strength.

The pairing is not accidental. Oil is inward richness. Iron and copper are public hardware. A people that has oil and no bars is plundered. A people that has bars and no oil is a prison. Sukkot holds both: the fragile roof of dependence, and the species taken in the public square. Yosef, today's ushpiza, lived the same pairing in one life — the private integrity of the house of Potiphar, then the iron administration of the storehouses.

Ein ka-El Yeshurun (33:26)

> *There is none like G-d, O Jeshurun, who rides the heavens to your help, and in His majesty the skies.*

After three tribal blessings the camera lifts. Jeshurun is the upright name of the people — not the name of a tribe. Rashi: the G-d of Jeshurun is unlike the patrons of the nations. Ibn Ezra and Sforno hear the verse as the reason the bars will hold: the lock is not the metal. The lock is the Rider.

Covenantal-republican resonance is clean here and should not be inflated. Limited power under higher law is not a modern import into Devarim 33. It is the grammar of the verse. The tribes have strength, oil, shoreline, and locks. None of that is self-grounding. *Ein ka-El*. A people that forgets the Rider will treat its bars as gods and its oil as entitlement. A people that remembers Him can lock a courtyard without becoming a jailer, and dip a foot in oil without becoming a glutton.

In the sukkah the verse is almost tactile. The roof is vegetation. The walls may be canvas. The Rider is not less present because the house is temporary. He rides the heavens *to your help* — the help is directed, not abstract.

III. Hayom Yom: The Lulav at the Place of Ashamnu

The Frierdiker Rebbe's comparison is precise.

Before davening there is a bitterness over one's sins. After that bitterness there can be *hislahavus* — an emotional lighting in the prayer itself. The *naanuim* encode the same sequence in the body. The lulav touches the *Ashamnu*-spot. Then it moves through the six directions, drawing down and sending out.

Several classical and Chassidic lines meet here.

1. **Vidui is not the opposite of the Four Species.** *Ashamnu* is the daily confession. The species are the festival's public joy. The Hayom Yom places them on one point of the chest. The heart that knows how to strike itself is the only heart that knows how to wave.

2. **Direction follows interiority.** The six motions of the lulav — the traditional *naanuim* toward the four winds and above and below — are a claim on the whole world. That claim is illegitimate if it has not first landed on the self. A man who waves at the horizons and has never touched his own *Ashamnu* is conducting a parade. A man who touches the spot and then waves is doing the mitzvah.
3. **Sukkot does not abolish Elul.** It metabolizes it. The King who was in the field in Elul is now the Rider over the hut. The accounting of the Ten Days is not shredded; it is bound into the lulav with the three rings that still hold hadassim and aravot. On Hoshana Rabbah, Friday, 2 October 2026, the willows will be beaten. The sequence is honest: touch the heart, wave the year, beat what must be beaten, then close the festival into Shemini Atzeret.

For the table: let a child tap the bound species lightly against his own chest before the first wave. Name the spot. *This is where we tell the truth. Then we send it out.*

IV. Tanya: The Shechinah Among Them — Iggeret HaKodesh 23, Opening

The Alter Rebbe opens the letter with the language of Daniel: “This matter is by decree of the wakeful ones and the word of the holy ones.” He means the Sages, likened to ministering angels, who taught in Avot: if ten sit and occupy themselves with Torah, the Shechinah dwells *among them*.

He draws a distinction that governs the rest of the epistle.

- When ten Jews merely gather, the Shechinah *hovers over them* — a *makif*, an encompassing light.
- When ten sit and learn Torah together, the Shechinah rests *among them* — a *pnimi*, an internalized indwelling.

The purpose of man, he writes, citing “this is the whole of man,” is this descent-for-ascent: the soul comes into a body so that, still in the body, it can draw the Shechinah into this lowest world by public Torah. No ascent is higher. The heavens and the heavens of the heavens cannot contain Him; He is magnified *toch* — in the midst of — Israel when they learn and keep mitzvot as a congregation of ten.

The Frierdiker Rebbe, in a later note on this passage, asks why the Sages derive the quorum of ten from the *toch* of the congregation of the spies — “separate yourselves from the midst of this congregation.” His answer: Moshe was insulating the people from the *makif* of evil, the transcendent intensity of *kelipah*. Holiness has a corresponding *makif*. Ten who learn or pray or do a mitzvah together elicit a transcendent light that fewer than ten cannot. And the verse “the Holy One is within you” adds the further claim: that encompassing light can become interior.

Individual study is rewarded. The Sages needed a verse even for that. They did not find a verse that an individual, by himself, draws the same indwelling. Reward can be portioned. Indwelling cannot be scaled down below the public threshold without changing its kind.

On Chol HaMoed the teaching is not theoretical. The sukkah is already a temporary congregation. The water-drawing joy is already public. Hoshana Rabbah will be a night of communal *Tikkun*. The Alter Rebbe’s appeal, which the rest of the letter will make explicit, is

that the hours between Minchah and Maariv be given to group study of *Ein Yaakov* and to the practical laws of the *Shulchan Aruch*. The festival must not become seven private moods under seven private roofs. The Shechinah that the hut remembers is the Shechinah that rests *among*.

Covenantal resonance, again without force: a minyan is the opposite of a mob. Ten is a threshold of public holiness, not a weapon of public passion. Authority to say a *davar shebikedushah* is granted to a formed congregation under law, not to a crowd that happens to be loud. Non-domination, in this key, is the refusal to let either the isolated self or the unformed mass pretend to be the dwelling of G-d.

V. Rambam: Mikvaot 8–10 and Positive Commandment 109

Positive Commandment 109: one who seeks to leave ritual impurity immerses in a mikveh. The mitzvah is not obligatory in the sense that a person must purify himself if he has no intention of entering the sacred precincts. It is the appointed means of return to *taharah*. Forty se'ah of gathered valid water, or a spring even in small quantity. Nothing may intervene between body and water. Sunset completes the day of immersion.

Chapters 8–10 of Hilchot Mikvaot are the engineering of that return.

Chapter 8 asks how waters join. A cavity, a crack, a pipe, a hole the size of the mouthpiece of a drinking-pouch — these are the measures by which one body of water becomes part of another. Mud that is of the water is not an intervention. Displacement and splash do not automatically undo the immersion. Connection has a shiur. Below the shiur, two pools remain two.

Chapter 9 ranks six grades of mikveh, from collected rainwater in a pit up to a living spring. A spring purifies even while flowing and without a minimum volume. Different waters serve different recoveries: the *zav*, the *metzora*, the sanctification of the *parah adumah*. Mixed waters, spoiled taste, rain-torrents, sea-waves — each has a ruling. Not every water is every purification.

Chapter 10 treats doubt. Because disqualification by drawn water is often rabbinic, a doubt about drawn water generally leaves the mikveh kosher. Presumptions differ in the Land and abroad. An uncertain immersion is not treated as if it were certain. Severe impurity and light impurity are not collapsed into one anxiety.

The sukkah is not a mikveh, and the comparison should stay disciplined. Still, the week is a week of joining. Clouds of glory surround. Four unlike species are bound until they act as one. Ten learners draw an indwelling that one learner cannot. Waters connect by measure, or they do not. People connect by Torah, or they share only a roof.

Practical avodah from these chapters is almost embarrassingly concrete. Check the connection. Do not invent a join that the shiur does not recognize. Do not despair of a doubt that the law resolves toward purity. Do not treat every water as if it were a spring. Grade the vessel. Then immerse without a film.

VI. Tehillim 97–103: The Lord Reigns, Light Is Sown

The monthly Tehillim for the twentieth of the month opens at the precise pitch of the day.

- **97** — *Hashem malach, teigel ha'aretz.* The Lord reigns; the earth rejoices. Cloud and thick darkness are around Him; righteousness and justice are the foundation of His throne. The same clouds that are the sukkah's secret.
- **98** — A new song. The rivers clap; the mountains sing. Public joy, not a private interior.
- **99** — The Lord reigns; the peoples tremble. He is holy. Moshe and Aharon among His priests, Shmuel among those who call. The holy Name is a public fact.
- **100** — *Mizmor l'todah.* Enter His gates with thanksgiving. The festival offering of thanks is the psalm's own name.
- **101** — David's vow of a house: I will sing of kindness and justice. No base thing before my eyes. The ushpiza Yosef could have recited it in Potiphar's house.
- **102** — A prayer of the afflicted when he wraps himself and pours out his speech. The *Ashamnu*-spot has a psalm.
- **103** — Bless the Lord, O my soul. He has not dealt with us according to our sins. As far as east from west He has distanced our transgressions. The *naanuim* to the east and the west have their verse.

Light is sown for the righteous, and for the upright of heart, gladness (97:11). Sown — not handed over as finished fruit. The harvest is later. Today is the sowing that the Days of Awe prepared and that Hoshana Rabbah will ask to seal.

VII. Ushpizin: Yosef, and the Frierdiker Rebbe

The sixth night and day of the festival host Yosef. In the Chabad pairing the Frierdiker Rebbe sits with him.

Yosef is the tzaddik who remains a tzaddik in a house that does not belong to him. He is also the provider who turns private integrity into public grain. The brothers meant evil. He named it, without softening, and then refused to let their evil be the last author of the story. *Elokim chashavah l'tovah.* That sentence is not optimism. It is jurisdiction. Someone higher was writing.

The Frierdiker Rebbe is the man who taught today's Hayom Yom about the lulav and the *Ashamnu*-spot. He is also the man who carried a whole world of Chassidim through confiscation, exile, and the beginning of a new map. His farbrengen comparison is not a homily added to the species. It is Yosef's sequence: first the truth in the closed room, then the open storehouses.

Set a place. Tell the children that the guest today is the one who would not leave his name in Egypt, and the Rebbe who would not let joy skip the heart.

VIII. Approaches and a Constructive Synthesis

Traditional readings of today's verses and practices do not all weigh the same thing.

- **Sifrei and Rashi** read the tribal blessings as land, locks, and livelihood — Dan's spring, Naphtali's lake, Asher's oil and bars. The verses are first a map.

- **Ibn Ezra and Sforno** lift *Ein ka-El Yeshurun* as the theological ground of the map: the Rider, not the hardware, is why the bars hold.
- **Chassidus**, in the Hayom Yom and in Iggeret 23, moves the same material inward and then public again: the heart must be touched; the Shechinah must be *among*, not only above.
- **Rambam** will not let purification be a feeling. Waters join by shiur. Grades differ. Doubt has a ruling.
- **Covenantal-republican reading**, used only where the text already speaks: Jeshurun is a people under a G-d who is unlike the nations' patrons; a minyan is a formed public under law; bars without a Rider become domination; oil without bars becomes appetite.

Synthesis, not a blend that erases distinctions: the map is real, the Rider is real, the heart is real, the shiur is real. Sukkot is the week in which those four are allowed to sit at one table. The hut is the furniture of that permission.

IX. Practical Avodah and Chinuch

One focus for the day. Before the first *naanuim*, touch the bound species to the *Ashamnu*-spot. Hold for a breath. Then wave. Do not skip the breath.

At the table. - Dan: a young lion is still a lion. Strength is not postponed. - Naphtali: being satisfied does not cancel the command to possess. - Asher: oil and bars belong together. - *Ein ka-El*: say the words in Hebrew and in English. There is none like G-d. - Yosef: one name, two rooms — the closed room of integrity, the open room of provision.

For the house. The Shechinah the Alter Rebbe describes rests *among* those who learn together. Ten is the classical threshold. Two parents and children learning a few lines of today's Chumash in the sukkah is already the direction of that teaching, even when the minyan is elsewhere. Do not wait for a perfect quorum to begin the sitting.

Toward Hoshana Rabbah. On the night of Hoshana Rabbah (Thursday night, 1 October 2026) the *Tikkun* is long and the willows will be beaten. Today is the last ordinary Chol HaMoed weekday before that threshold. Finish what the hut still owes: a guest, a line of Tehillim, a child who has held the etrog long enough to know it is a fruit.

X. Extended Bibliography

Primary texts - Devarim 33:22–26, with Rashi, Onkelos, Ibn Ezra, Sforno, Netziv *Haamek Davar*. Sefaria: Deuteronomy 33 - Bamidbar 29:29–34 — musaf of the sixth day. Sefaria: Numbers 29 - Tehillim 97–103. Sefaria: Psalms 97 - Tanya, Iggeret HaKodesh 23 (opening). Chabad.org: Iggeret 23 - Rambam, Mishneh Torah, Hilchot Mikvaot 8–10; Sefer HaMitzvot, Positive 109. Chabad.org: Mikvaot 8 · Positive 109 - Hayom Yom, 20 Tishrei. Lchaim: 20 Tishrei 5787 - Mishnah Avot 3:6 — ten who sit and occupy themselves with Torah. Sefaria: Avot 3 - Sukkah 51a–53a — Simchat Beit HaShoeivah. Sefaria: Sukkah 51

Chassidus and Rebbeim - Hayom Yom, compiled by the Lubavitcher Rebbe from the Frierdiker Rebbe's teachings, 20 Tishrei entry on the lulav and *Ashamnu*. - Frierdiker Rebbe's note on the *toch* of the spies and the *makif* of holiness, cited in the standard annotated Iggeret 23. - Maharash, *lechatchilah ariber* — standing maxim, already bound to these verses on 13 Tishrei, still live in Dan's spring.

Halakhah of the day - Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim 651–661 — Four Species and *naanuim*. - Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim 640–666 — sukkah on Chol HaMoed. - Rambam, Hilchot Shofar veSukkah veLulav.

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Calendar and context - Chabad.org Jewish Calendar, 20 Tishrei 5787 / 1 October 2026. Daily calendar - Passing of R. Yehoshua Heshel of Kraków, 20 Tishrei 5423 — teacher-field of the Shach and the Taz.

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